

FORMULA 1

2026 SEASON

Technical & Sporting Regulations

A Beginner's Guide to Formula 1

2026 Regulation Overview

The Most Significant Overhaul in Over a Decade

350 kW

MGU-K

768 kg

Min Weight

100%

Sustainable Fuel

\$215M

Budget Cap

The 2026 Formula 1 regulations represent the most significant overhaul in over a decade. Every major area of the car is affected: power units, aerodynamics, chassis dimensions, fuel, and the financial regulations. The goals are to improve racing, increase sustainability, reduce costs, and attract new manufacturers.

Why 2026?

The current Concorde Agreement, power unit regulations, and aerodynamic rules all converge for a reset in 2026. This alignment created a natural opportunity for a comprehensive regulation change and attracted new entrants like Audi and Cadillac/GM.

Power Unit Overhaul

The 2026 power unit is a radical departure from the current design. The electrical component of the powertrain is dramatically increased, targeting a roughly 50/50 split between electric and combustion power.

Change	Detail
MGU-H	Eliminated entirely, simplifying the power unit and reducing costs
MGU-K Output	Increases from 120 kW to 350 kW (nearly triple)
Battery Capacity	Significantly increased to support higher MGU-K output
ICE Output	Decreases to approximately 400 kW, down from ~550 kW
Total System Output	Remains similar to current cars (~750 kW / ~1,000 bhp)
Engine RPM	Limit remains at 15,000

Power Unit Suppliers

Supplier	Teams Supplied	Status
Ferrari	Ferrari, Haas, Cadillac	Incumbent
Mercedes	Mercedes, McLaren, Alpine, Williams	Incumbent
Honda RBPT	Red Bull Racing, Racing Bulls, Aston Martin	Incumbent
Audi	Sauber/Audi	New entrant

Why Remove the MGU-H?

The MGU-H was the most complex and expensive component of the current power unit, creating a barrier for new manufacturers. Its removal lowers costs, simplifies the architecture, and was a key condition for Audi's entry and GM/Cadillac's future engine plans.

Sustainable Fuels

100% Advanced Sustainable Fuel for 2026

For the first time, Formula 1 mandates 100% advanced sustainable fuel. This is a cornerstone of the sport's commitment to reaching net-zero carbon by 2030.

- Fuel must be 100% sustainable (non-fossil origin)
- Can be produced from municipal waste, agricultural waste, or captured carbon combined with green hydrogen (e-fuels)
- Must be a 'drop-in' fuel compatible with standard fuel infrastructure and similar energy density
- Fuel flow rate adjusted to account for the shift in power balance toward electric energy
- All fuel suppliers must meet FIA sustainability certification standards

Real-World Impact

F1's sustainable fuel development is intended to accelerate technology that can eventually be used in road cars and other transportation. The goal is to prove that high-performance sustainable fuels are viable at the highest level of motorsport.

Active Aerodynamics

The 2026 cars introduce active aerodynamics as a replacement for the Drag Reduction System (DRS). Instead of a simple rear wing flap, both the front and rear wings can change their configuration in real time.

Feature	DRS (2011-2025)	Active Aero (2026+)
Wings affected	Rear only	Front and rear
Activation	Within 1s of car ahead	Available to all cars
Detection zones	Specific DRS zones	Speed/zone-based
Modes	Open / Closed	Multiple configurations
Driver control	Manual button	Automatic + driver input
Purpose	Reduce rear drag for overtaking	Full drag/downforce management

X-Mode (low drag): Wing elements open/flatten on straights to minimize drag and maximize top speed.

Z-Mode (high downforce): Wings in maximum downforce configuration for cornering and braking zones.

Car Design Changes

- Minimum weight: 768 kg (down from 798 kg, a 30 kg reduction)
- Wheelbase: 200 mm shorter than current cars
- Overall width: 100 mm narrower
- Venturi tunnels eliminated; replaced by a flat floor with larger rear diffuser
- Ground effect downforce still the primary source of grip, but generated differently
- Front wing simpler with fewer elements, working with active aero system

- Updated crash structures, halo remains mandatory

2025 vs 2026 Comparison

Side-by-Side Regulation Differences

Category	2025 Regulations	2026 Regulations
MGU-H	Yes (120 kW harvest)	Eliminated
MGU-K Output	120 kW	350 kW
ICE Output	~550 kW	~400 kW
Total Power	~750 kW	~750 kW (different split)
Electric Share	~20%	~50%
Fuel	10% sustainable blend	100% sustainable
Rear Wing	DRS (passive)	Active aero (multi-mode)
Front Wing	Fixed	Active aero
Floor	Venturi tunnels	Flat floor + diffuser
Min. Weight	798 kg	768 kg
Width	2000 mm	1900 mm
Wheelbase	~3,600 mm (typical)	~3,400 mm
Budget Cap	~\$140M	\$215M (expanded scope)
Teams	10	11 (Cadillac joins)
PU Suppliers	4 (Ferrari, Merc, Honda, Renault)	4 (Ferrari, Merc, Honda, Audi)

Budget Cap Changes

- Headline cap: \$215 million (up from ~\$140M)
- More items now fall under the cap, including previously excluded costs like PU development and marketing
- Power unit cost cap introduced separately to control engine development spending
- Penalty structure remains: minor overages (< 5%) result in fines and reduced wind tunnel time; major overages can result in points deductions
- New team exemptions: Cadillac receives a temporary uplift in their first seasons for startup costs

Why the Increase?

The headline number looks much higher, but the real-terms spending limit has not increased dramatically. The broader scope brings more team spending under scrutiny, which should improve competitive balance and financial fairness across the grid.

Sporting Regulation Updates

Grid Expansion: With 11 teams and 22 drivers, qualifying knockout thresholds are adjusted: Q1 eliminates 5, Q2 eliminates 5 more, and Q3 features the top 12.

Sprint Format: Continues with 6 events. Points remain 8-7-6-5-4-3-2-1 for top 8 finishers.

PU Allocation: Each driver is allowed a specific number of PU components per season before incurring grid penalties. Allocation adjusted for simplified design.

Testing: Pre-season testing expanded to three sessions. In-season testing slightly increased for the first year. Wind tunnel / CFD allocations based on inverse championship position.

The Big Picture

The 2026 regulations represent F1's vision for the future: cars that are lighter, more electric, powered by sustainable fuels, and designed to produce better racing. For fans, expect different-sounding cars (more electric whine, less turbocharged whoosh), new overtaking dynamics with active aero replacing DRS, and a larger, more diverse grid.